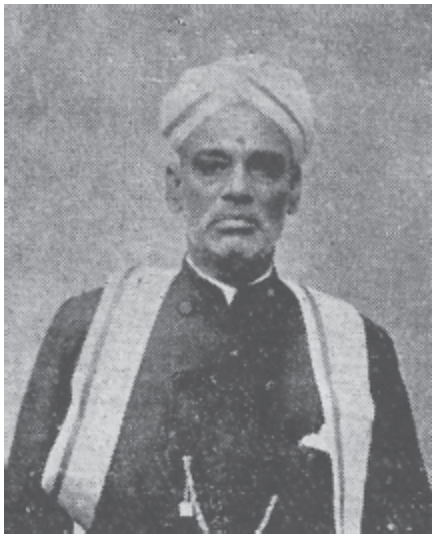


Figure 10: K.R. Guruswami Aiyar

The key troublemaker was K.R. Guruswami Aiyar (Figure 10). A graduate of the Madras Christian College, he was a high court advocate. A member of the Madras Legislative Council, he belonged to the moderate wing of the Indian National Congress. Involved in SSNCo much before its registration as honorary legal adviser, he provided pro bono services but did not take shares despite persuasion by many. His younger brother K.R. Venkatarama Aiyar was, however, V.O. Chidambaram Pillai's strong associate and played an important role both in the company and in the political movement.

In August 1907, K.R. Guruswami Aiyar, while chairing a public talk by G. Subramania Iyer at Tirunelveli, remarked that the time was not yet ripe for the political boycott of the British—he did not seem to notice that this observation did not go down well with the crowd.[1]

K.R. Guruswami Aiyar rallied many directors for his coup, planting fear in their minds of provoking government displeasure. Leading up to its directors' meeting on 12 July 1907, some 'well-to-do-men'—in the words of the district collector—and the chief men of The Tinnevelly Bank met SSNCo's directors. Fresh capital was urgently needed since the funds raised had been exhausted by the purchase of steamers, and the meeting was